



Chris Campbell works out in the new weight room on Thursday. The Henry Student Activity Center is only the second phase in a massive redesign of the school's campus.

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- Trophy showcase lobby.

ous. "It's a dream come true," said Mike Quinn, Gaston Day athletic director and varsity boys' basketball coach.

The Henry Student Activity Center is a stark contrast to the old gym in the school's main building. Built in the late 1960s, the white dome of the old gymnasium can still be seen from the road as you approach.

"It's the complete opposite of what we used to have," Quinn said. "The old gym is just that, an old gym. This is an athletic center."

He's not kidding. There are four locker rooms, a weight room, coaches' offices, locker room offices, classrooms and a training room that includes two whirlpools. Gaston Day has also hired Matt Gibbons, a nationally certified athletic trainer with a bachelor's degree in athletic training.

The athletic center has an indoor track that circles the bas-

Athletes aren't the only ones affected by the Henry Center. The facility caters to the entire student body.

"You hear nothing but good things from everyone," junior basketball player Jonathan Helms said.

The Henry Student Activity Center is only the second phase in a massive redesign of the school's campus. The first was the Pamela Kimbrell Warlick Performing Arts Center.

A new school cafeteria next to the athletic facility will be completed in the spring and will serve students next fall. The school also has tentative plans for new academic buildings along the perimeter of the open grass between the Henry Center and the school's existing main building - forming a college-like quadrangle.

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Pair of bald eagles halts Belmont development

By JOE DEPRIEST
Staff Writer

BELMONT — The discovery of a nesting pair of bald eagles along the Catawba River, a rare occurrence in this corner of North Carolina, has put a temporary halt to a developer's plans to build a small neighborhood.

Federal wildlife officials, who have confirmed the eagle sightings, say it's only the second N.C. case where birds and people want to build at the same spot.

The builder in the Belmont area meets all the city's codes and regulations at the 12-acre site, but eagles are protected under the federal Endangered Species Act and Bald Eagle Protection Act.

That means 750 feet around the tree can't be disturbed during nesting season, which lasts from about Dec. 15 through May 15. The developer says the tree is on the back corner of a lot where a waterline was planned.

Mark Cantrell, an Asheville-based biologist for the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service, met with the developer Friday. He said the project will have to be halted, possibly for several months.

Eagles usually build several

Since the 1960s, when their numbers fell to just 450 nesting pairs nationwide, eagles have been designated an endangered species. None were recorded in North Carolina by the 1970s.

nests but end up using only one. Wildlife officials will monitor the tree to determine whether the birds will be using it this season or next.

"We've never been confronted by anything like this before," said Mayor Pro Tem Jane Ray, who heard about the eagles last week from people who'd spotted the young male and female eagles in December. "The developer has been very cooperative."

For the eagles' protection, she didn't want to reveal the builder's name or location of the nest, which is on private property inside the city's jurisdiction.

"The bottom line is that these birds are protected from harassment," Ray said. "If these birds leave, the government will want to know why."

Cantrell said 28 eagles' nests were found in North Carolina in 1998, 33 in 1999 and 34 in 2000. A completed nest can be 5 feet wide

and 3 feet deep.

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Eagles were almost wiped out by chemicals such as DDT. The chemical accumulated in dead and dying fish, which make up most of the birds' diet, Cantrell said. DDT caused eagles to lay eggs with thin shells that rarely survived to hatch. The chemical was banned in 1972. The eagles were given protected status, and their numbers began to increase.

Bald eagles are making a comeback in North and South Carolina, and while most of the birds are showing up in coastal regions, there is also resurgence around rivers and lakes in the west near booming residential areas, Cantrell said.

How do eagles and developers

coexist?

"It's usually a standoff until you find out the birds' precise needs and where they're going," Cantrell said. "So far, we've worked out solutions generally meeting both their needs."

Alan Barnhardt, executive director of the Carolina Raptor Center near Huntersville, recalls that last spring a bald eagle perched outside the center and "communed with the seven bald eagles we have in our large aviary."

"They're (eagles) out there," he said. "An adult can have a wingtip to wingtip span of 6 feet. They are big, majestic birds."

Ray said the Belmont residents who spotted the eagles were walking shortly before sunset.

"The birds were flying about tree-top level," she said.

When Ray contacted Cantrell, she found out about the high-protection status the eagles have under federal law. She also learned about the complications the nest might cause the builder.

"This area around the nest can't be disturbed," she said. "You can't move one pine cone or one spoonful of dirt. And the federal law supersedes the city's regulations."

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